amoeba is constantly splitting, each time the resulting amoebas having the same memories as the parent. Our amoeba hence does not have a life line, but a life tree." Wheeler was put off by the blatantness of this (quite accurate) metaphor, scribbling in the margin of the manuscript, "Split? Better words needed." Advisor and student were constantly tussling over the best way to express the new theory, with Wheeler advocating caution and prudence while Everett favored bold clarity.

In 1956, as Everett was working on finishing his dissertation, Wheeler visited Copenhagen and presented the new scenario to Bohr and his colleagues, including Aage Petersen. He attempted to present it anyway; by this time the wave-functions-collapse-and-don't-ask-embarrassing-questions-about-exactly-how school of quantum theory had hardened into conventional wisdom, and those who accepted it weren't interested in revisiting the foundations when there was so much interesting applied work to be done. Letters from Wheeler, Everett, and Petersen flew back and forth across the Atlantic, continuing when Wheeler returned to Princeton and helped Everett craft the final form of his dissertation. The agony of this process is reflected in the evolution of the paper itself: Everett's first draft was titled "Quantum Mechanics by the Method of the Universal Wave Function," and a revised version was called "Wave Mechanics Without Probability." This document, later dubbed the "long version" of the thesis, wasn't published until 1973. A "short version" was finally submitted for Everett's PhD as "On the Foundations of Quantum Mechanics," and eventually published in 1957 as "'Relative State' Formulation of Quantum Mechanics." It omitted many of the juicier sections Everett had originally composed, including examinations of the foundations of probability and information theory and an overview of the quantum measurement problem, focusing instead on applications to quantum cosmology. (No amoebas appear in the published paper, but Everett did manage to insert the word "splitting" in a footnote added in proof while Wheeler wasn't looking.) Furthermore, Wheeler wrote an "assessment" article that was published alongside Everett's, which suggested that the new theory was radical and important, while at the same time attempting to paper over its manifest differences with the Copenhagen approach.

The arguments continued, without much headway being made. It is worth quoting from a letter Everett wrote to Petersen, in which his frustration comes through: